Annotation Instructions

Regret and disappointment in customer reviews, round 2

1. Your task

You will read 397 short Amazon product reviews and record, for each one, whether the reviewer expresses **regret** (blaming their own decision) or **disappointment** (blaming the product or circumstances). Your labels become the human answer key against which we test several AI systems in a research paper. The paper cannot be published without them, so careful, independent work matters more than speed.

Before you start, read the background document, *Regret and Disappointment: Background*. It takes about 15 minutes.

2. Rules

These rules make your labels usable as independent human judgements. Please follow all of them.

- **Work alone.** Do not discuss specific reviews with the other annotator, or anyone else, until both of you have returned your files.
- **Use no AI or automation.** Do not paste reviews into ChatGPT, Copilot, Gemini or any other AI tool, and do not use scripts, macros or formulas to fill in labels. We check the returned files for signs of automated filling.
- **Read every review yourself** and judge it from the text. There are no right answers to look up.
- **Work in your own workbook** in Microsoft Excel. Do not sort, filter-and-delete, or reorder rows, and do not edit columns A to D.
- **A few reviews have clear, known answers.** They are mixed into the set unmarked to check data quality. Treat every review the same way.
- **Sign the declaration** sheet in the workbook when you finish.

3. Your files

File	What it is
annotation_round2_coder_1.xlsx or annotation_round2_coder_2.xlsx	Your workbook. Use only the one assigned to you.
Regret_and_Disappointment_Background (PDF or Word)	The theory you need, with examples.
Annotation_Instructions (this document)	The task, the rules, and the decision rules for hard cases.

Your workbook has five sheets:

Sheet	What to do
declaration	Read it before you start. Fill in your name, the dates and the hours spent, and sign it when you finish.
practice	10 warm-up reviews that are not part of the study. Do them first, then check your answers against Section 7.

Sheet	What to do
coding	**The main task: 397 reviews.** Fill in columns E to M for every row.
codebook	A short copy of the rules, for reference while you work.
meta	Do not edit.

4. Steps

1. Read the background document (15 minutes).
2. Open your workbook and read the declaration sheet.
3. Code the 10 reviews in the practice sheet, then compare your answers with Section 7. Re-read Section 6 for any you got wrong.
4. Code the coding sheet, top to bottom, in several sessions. Take a break at least every hour; tired coders make more errors.
5. Check that every row has columns E, F and L filled in.
6. Fill in and sign the declaration sheet.
7. Save the workbook under its original name and email it to Sarthak Pattnaik (spattna1@bu.edu) by [return date].

Expect about 4 to 7 hours in total: about 30 seconds per review for the required columns and about a minute with every column.

5. What to fill in

Every coded column has a drop-down menu. Use it instead of typing.

Col	Column	Required ?	Values	What to record
E	primary_emotion	**Required**	REGRET, DISAPPOINTMENT, BOTH, NEITHER	The main emotion the review expresses.
F	forced_choice	**Required**	REGRET, DISAPPOINTMENT	If you had to pick one of the two. Fill it in even when E is BOTH or NEITHER.
G	cf_focus	Please fill	BEHAVIOR, SITUATION, NONE	What the reviewer imagines changing (Section 6.2).
H	counterfactual	Please fill	1–7	How much "if only / should have / I wish" thinking. 1 = none, 7 = a lot.
I	responsibility	Please fill	1–7	Who the reviewer blames. **1 = entirely the product, seller or circumstances; 7 = entirely the reviewer.**
J	controllability	Please fill	1–7	Could the reviewer have prevented the outcome? 1 = not at all, 7 = completely.
K	affect	Please fill	1–7	How strong the negative feeling is. 1 = mild, 7 = intense.
L	certainty	**Required**	LOW, MEDIUM, HIGH	How sure you are about column E.
M	notes	Optional	free text	Only for odd cases: sarcasm, mixed reviews, unreadable text. Leave it empty otherwise.

Check the direction of the scales. For a typical disappointment review, responsibility and controllability are low (1 or 2). For a typical regret review they are high (5 to 7). If you find yourself giving 7 for responsibility to a review you labelled disappointment, re-read the scale.

6. Decision rules

6.1 Regret or disappointment

If the review…	Code
Describes a defect, poor quality, short battery life, a damaged or wrong item sent, or "not as described"	DISAPPOINTMENT
Says "won't buy again", "stick with Duracell" or "going with a name brand next time", **without** blaming the past decision	DISAPPOINTMENT (a plan, not self-blame)
Says the same **and** blames the past decision: "I should have stuck with Duracell"	REGRET
Says "waste of money" on its own	DISAPPOINTMENT
Says "I wasted my money, should have listened to the reviews"	REGRET
Blames the reviewer for trusting the brand, not reading the description or reviews, ordering the wrong item, or misusing the product ("my fault", "I ordered AAA by mistake")	REGRET
Missed the return window and blames themselves ("I waited too long")	REGRET
Missed the return window and blames the policy ("their return policy is too short")	DISAPPOINTMENT
Shows clear self-blame **and** clear product blame, with neither dominant	BOTH, and pick the stronger one in F
Is "ok", "not great", a question, spam, or a mostly positive review	NEITHER, and pick the closer one in F
Says "I expected too much"	Usually DISAPPOINTMENT. REGRET only if the reviewer says they should have chosen differently. Add a note.

A first-person sentence is not enough for regret. "I put them in my remote and they died in a day" blames the product.

6.2 Counterfactual focus (column G)

A counterfactual is a thought about how things could have gone differently: "if only…", "should have…", "I wish…", "next time I would…".

- **BEHAVIOR**: the reviewer imagines acting differently. "If only I had read the reviews." "I should have bought Duracell."
- **SITUATION**: the reviewer imagines the product or circumstances being different. "It should have lasted longer." "I wish it had a bigger screen."
- **NONE**: no such thought. A plain complaint ("They died in a day") is NONE, even though it blames the product.

7. Practice answers

Do the practice sheet before reading this section. The answers below follow the rules in Section 6. Small differences in certainty or ratings do not matter; differences in E or F mean a rule needs another look.

#	Review (shortened)	E	F	G	Why
1	"…without checking to see if they would even be compatible. They weren't. It's my fault for not checking this…"	REGRET	REGRET	BEHAVIOR	"My fault for not checking" blames the reviewer's own decision.
2	"These batteries don't last very long at all. Save your money…"	DISAPP.	DISAPP.	NONE	Product failure, no self-blame.
3	"feel it should have come with paperwhite kindle and that I should not have had to buy it"	DISAPP.	DISAPP.	SITUATION	"Should have come with" imagines the product being different. "I should not have had to buy it" complains about the bundle, not the reviewer's choice.
4	"…most of the brand new batteries contained in the box arrived DEAD…"	DISAPP.	DISAPP.	NONE	Defective product.
5	"…battery life is not as long as my preferred choice of battery. Will go back to my original choice…"	DISAPP.	DISAPP.	NONE	A plan for next time, without self-blame.
6	"PPI too low for reading.. kinda regret getting it.. should've gotten a used ipad instead."	REGRET	REGRET	BEHAVIOR	Explicit regret over the reviewer's own choice.
7	"…After 4 months the charging port came loose… Amazon does not stand behind this product…"	DISAPP.	DISAPP.	NONE	Blames the product and the companies.
8	"Battery lasts a long time but I actually like my old Fire more."	NEITHER or DISAPP.	DISAPP.	NONE	A mild preference. Either code in E is acceptable.
9	"…Why isn't there a manual or step by step guide… Thanks for any help."	NEITHER	DISAPP.	NONE	Mostly a request for help. If forced, the reviewer blames the missing manual.
10	"…only 1/3 of the batteries actually worked… this was not a cheap buy at all."	DISAPP.	DISAPP.	NONE	"Not a cheap buy" judges the product's value, not the reviewer's choice.

Questions about the task, not about specific reviews, can go to Sarthak Pattnaik (spattna1@bu.edu). Thank you for your help.